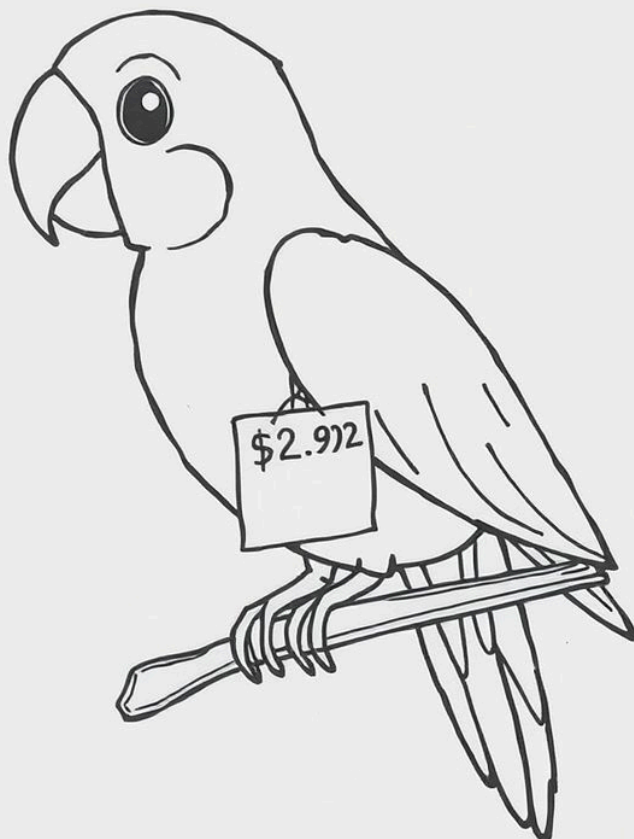
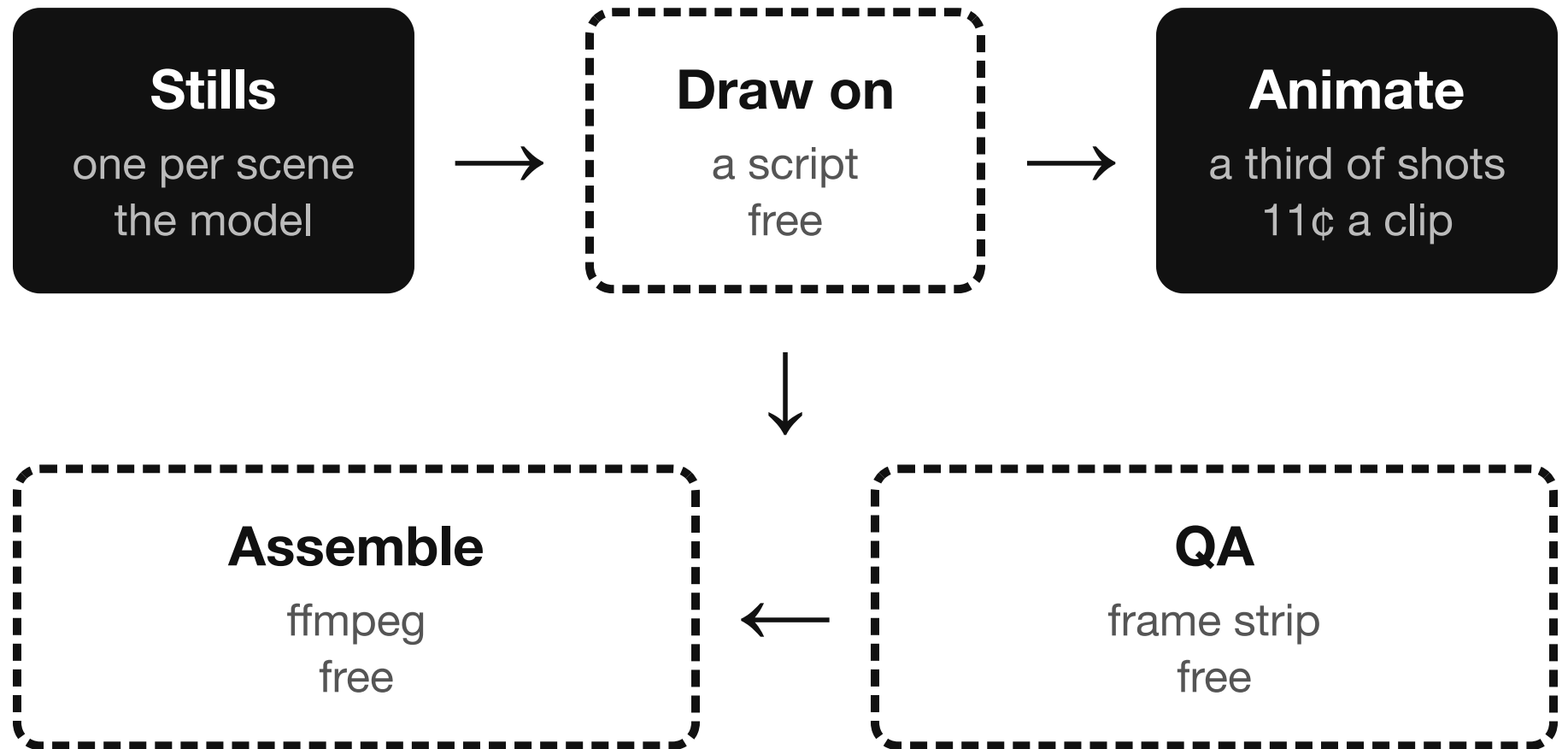


A ninety second animated brand film cost me \$2.92 in API calls.

Here is where the money went and where it didn't.



Five steps. Two of them cost anything.



Solid boxes are the model. Dashed boxes are a script.

STEP ONE

One still per scene. Locked art style.

Black marker line art on white.

Every prompt ends with the same style sentence, word for word.

The style lock matters more than the model.

STEP TWO

The draw on trick.

A local script replays each still like a hand is drawing it.

Threshold the linework. Reveal it stroke by stroke. Fade in the color.

Costs nothing. It's image processing.

And a static image suddenly feels animated.

STEP THREE

Animate only the shots that earn it.

About a third of the stills go through image to video. Eleven cents a clip.

Boring prompts. “The parrot blinks and tilts its head.”

Subtle prompts survive.

Ambitious prompts grow a second parrot.

STEP FOUR AND FIVE

QA with a frame strip. Assemble with ffmpeg.

Eight frames tiled in one image. You see the exact frame the ghost parrot shows up. Reject, retry once, move on.

Voiceover, caption pills, music bed, concat.

Total in API calls. \$2.92.

Pay the model only for the thing only the model can do.

Everything else is a script.

What's the most expensive step in your pipeline that a script could be doing instead?